strength and for show' – metal on metal threw sparks in the air. Startled and angry, Dalsingar trampled the man – just as a boy of fifteen fell from the roof onto Dalsingar's back. Akbar's men would have killed him, but Akbar wouldn't allow it.

Instead, speed on! They reached the compound – a contingent of soldiers had surrounded it as the villagers fired volley after desperate volley upon them. Seven arrows struck Akbar's shield, five pierced through. 'Who are you,' cried one of Akbar's soldiers, impressed with his courage, 'that I may praise you to His Majesty?'

Akbar lifted his visor in reply.

He drove Dalsingar at the compound wall and others joined him. The wall fell, the villagers retreated. Now, they were all trapped in a house. Akbar ordered a hole made in its roof, and fire thrown in. Night fell as flames consumed the rebels. There is no record of how long Akbar watched them burn; whether he basked in the glow of victory, or retreated as the scent of burning flesh filled the air.

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Paronkh was no Panipat, no defining battle for the books, but it was the first that Akbar led, and he won. Similarly, appointing Shamsuddin Ataka his vakil may not have been the most important administrative decision that Akbar ever took, but it was a decision he took alone – and he stuck by it. In the second month of his seventh year on the throne, Akbar's veil had become decidedly worn and translucent with age.

Still, it hadn't slipped away.

A little after Paronkh, Shah Tahmasp of Persia finally sent condolences for Humayun's passing. The embassy, led by the shah's cousin,[40] may have signalled an emerging respect for Akbar in the region. After seven years on the throne, he was more than a flash in the pan; though in a painting of the scene, he hasn't quite outgrown his boyhood. Slim, beardless, his moustache an adolescent wisp, Akbar looks almost as young as the pageboys standing behind him. At least, in the painting, the emperor is enthroned and attended upon with some formality;[41] Abul Fazl describes the event with all the requisite pomp: great gifts from each side to the other, the ambassador reading out the shah's letter after 'kissing the carpet'. In